

CPC Adult Sunday Studies

Fall 2026 |

The Wonders of Communal Worship #2

The Distinctives of Communal Worship

Last Week: Worship starts and ends with God. Our worship reflects what we believe about him, and Scriptures teach that all of creation is meant to worship God. The unique, redemptive presence of God is promised to his people in the Old Testament Temple and fulfilled in Christ and the Church. Last week addressed the WHO and the WHY of worship; this week, we're discussing the WHEN, HOW, and WHAT of worship.

1 | WHEN OUGHT GOD TO BE WORSHIPPED?

Read Exodus 20:8-11 and Hebrews 4:8-11

- The 4th Commandment is not obsolete! We fulfill it in Christ—just as Joshua led Israel to the promised Land, but they still observed a Sabbath, so too are Christians called to observe a Sabbath, that points us to the final Sabbath rest day of Jesus' return. Jesus never broke the Sabbath, only the rabbinical tradition that had risen around it. (See our previous class on the ten commandments)
- *Moved from the last day to the first day* - see John 20.19, 26; Acts 20.7; 1Cor. 16.1-2; Rev. 1.10 for worship on the Lord's Day being the assumption. We start our week now with the grace of the new creation that defines our subsequent work, instead of waiting until the end of the week after our work.
- See last week's handout for more on the Sabbath and Heb. 3.7-4.13 - "The Sabbath day is an **eschatological sign**. In other words, our **weekly Sabbath-rest is a recurring pointer to that consummation**....Our great privilege under the New Covenant is to **start each week with the Sabbath**. That's a sign—because of Jesus' resurrection on the first day of the week—not only that the new creation is '*ready to be revealed in the last time*' (1 Pet. 1:5), but also that our Lord Jesus Christ has actually already begun the new creation. Because we **still look forward** to the future consummation, when we will enter God's rest in perfection, we continue to have a weekly Sabbath in the New Testament. Because in Jesus Christ we have **already** entered God's rest in principle, we begin the week with the Sabbath. . . . The rest itself—ceasing as much as possible from those activities that are appropriate on the

other six days of the week—has positive meaning. The Lord's Day is about worship because it is first of all **about the gospel**. It is a sign, a witness both to the church and to the watching world, that '*you are not your own*' (1 Cor. 6:19). We are depending on God, not on ourselves, to provide for us. . . . The weekly Sabbath is a God-given sign that our lives are not meaningless and without purpose. Every time we neglect to consecrate the Sabbath day to God, **we actually steal hope from ourselves**. Every time we fail to keep the day holy to God, we actually obscure our witness to the world of hope in Christ. Every Sabbath day is a gracious reminder that our '*labor in the Lord is not in vain*' (1 Cor. 15:58)." - Gaffin, "The Lord's Day: A Sign of Hope"

Questions to consider in remembering the Sabbath

- How can I plan the rest of my week so that Sunday can be a day of worship and rest?
- How should I schedule travel and vacation? At least, go to church out of town!
- What activities should I (not) do on Sunday? Only extraordinary necessity (sickness, job, etc.) should prevent us from worship

2 | HOW OUGHT GOD TO BE WORSHIPPED?

1. *Doxologically - For His Glory (last week)*
2. *Regulated and Directed - By His Word*
3. *In Communion - With the Triune God who Dwells among his people*
4. *Covenantally - According to the Logic of the Gospel (starting next week)*
5. *Communally - With God's People*
6. *Missionally - Open to All God's People*
7. *In the Vernacular - In the Languages and Nations that God Created*

Notice the movement of the above principles: worship is *for* God and done according to his good will and pleasure as he's revealed in his *Word*; because of *who* God is we worship *to* the Father, *through* the Son, *by* the Spirit, according to the logic of the *gospel*, which brings us into communion with him; God relates to us as a *people* bought communally in Christ, so we worship together, always hoping to reach more (*missional*) of his people until his return—worship which must be done in the *language* of the people God is reaching and going to be glorified among.

There is also a double movement happening: from God to his people; and from his people to God. This movement happens throughout the service and speaks to the communion with God, for which we are made.

REGULATED & DIRECTED BY HIS WORD

Why can't we just worship however we want?

Read Ezekiel 20:27-32

"... wherever they saw any high hill or any leafy tree, there they offered their sacrifices and there they presented the provocation of their offering. . . " - a common prophetic rebuke against Israel's syncretism, as they tried to mold together the worship of the LORD with the worshipping practices of the surrounding nations, which got so evil it even led them to child sacrifice. Their problem was not atheism, or merely worshipping other gods like Baal and Asherah, but worshipping the LORD in the manner of Baal or in other places besides the Temple, as God appointed.

*Jer. 7 - "Will you steal, murder, commit adultery, swear falsely, **make offerings to Baal, and go after other gods that you have not known**, 10 and then come and stand before me in this house, which is called by my name, and say, 'We are delivered!'—only to go on doing all these abominations? 11 Has this house, which is called by my name, become a den of robbers in your eyes?"*

WORD | Elements "Regulated" - what essentials or elements of worship must be done

1. Songs/prayers; 2. Word; 3. Sacraments; 4. Fellowship / collection

These are the four essentials to new covenant worship. Note Acts 2.42, *"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."* Without any one of these, we are disobeying God as he has commanded us to gather in his name. Note 1Cor. 10-14, where Paul is regulating the prayers, engagement with the Word, and how to observe the Lord's Supper. The Old Testament pattern of worship also included similar elements of songs and prayers, reading of the Law, administration of sacrifices, and distribution of mercy.

Note the difference between doing only what is positively prescribed (our view here) and merely avoiding what is forbidden (other traditions).

This "regulative principle" which applies to the Church beyond worship is grounded in our doctrine of Christ's sufficiency and the sufficiency of Scripture. WCF 1.6 reads, *"The whole counsel of God, concerning all things necessary for his own glory, man's salvation, faith, and life, is either **expressly set down** in Scripture, or by **good and necessary consequence** may be deduced from Scripture: unto which nothing at any time is to be added, whether by new revelations of the Spirit, or traditions of men..."*

WORD BECOMES FLESH | Forms “Directed” - what forms or styles ought to be used in worship

The form of worship distinctive in Presbyterian churches is the “directory” approach—as opposed to no forms at all prescribed in Scripture (Baptist, nondenominational) or all forms prescribed (Roman Catholic, Anglican, Lutheran). We believe no specific forms are prescribed because no language is privileged in the global church over another, but that every form ought to be “directed” by the Word. WCF 1.6 continues, “. . . there are some circumstances concerning the worship of God, and government of the Church, common to human actions and societies, which are to be ordered by the light of nature and Christian prudence, according to the general rules of the Word, which are always to be observed.”

In other words, if the element is **song**, then we must use the “circumstances . . . common to human actions and societies,” “the light of nature and Christian prudence,” and “the general rules of the Word” to determine the **types, lengths, styles, etc.** of those songs.

Notice there is no “Word” without some flesh, there is no song without a culture because we cannot experience God without being particular humans.

WORD BECOMES ALL FLESH | For the Purpose of Communion with God in Every Culture

- **The question of forms** will be answered differently depending on what we think the worship service is *for*:
 - If worship is primarily like a revival, getting people to make a **decision for Christ**, then the songs will be geared toward priming people for that decision, preparing their emotions accordingly.
 - If worship is a **work we must now perform**, worship is something we do, out of duty, we sing, we pray for the world, the sermon is exhortative - Jesus is our example. Songs would be motivational or human-centered.
 - In practice this is unitarian because it “has no doctrine of the mediator or sole priesthood of Christ, is human-centered, has no proper doctrine of the Holy Spirit, is too often non-sacramental, and can engender weariness.” Leads to “Do-it-yourself”, legal worship - basically Arian or Pelagian, ignoring that Christ is still human in heaven. Although it stresses the God-humanward movement in Christ, the human-Godward movement is still ours! “It emphasizes **our** faith, **our** decision, **our** response in an event theology which short-circuits the vicarious humanity of Christ and belittles

the union with God. . . . it is to imply that God **throws us back upon ourselves** to make our response. It ignores the fact that God has already provided for us that response which alone is acceptable to him." - James Torrance

- If it's primarily about **communion with God for his glory**, then the songs will be according to the logic of what it means to commune with God. Communion with God according to the Scriptures happens through Christ in the gospel.

- ***Jesus is our Worship Leader!***

- *Hebrews 8 - "Now the point in what we are saying is this: we have such a high priest, one who is seated at the right hand of the throne of the Majesty in heaven, a minister in the holy places, in the true tent that the Lord set up, not man."*
 - Notice the present tense language. Insofar as we are united to Christ in worship, we are worshipping in the true, heavenly tent!
- Ps. 22 (which starts "*my God my God, why have you forsaken me?*") is quoted in Heb. 2 - "*That is why he is not ashamed to call them brothers, saying, "I will tell of your name to my brothers; in the midst of the congregation I will sing your praise."* (Ps.22.22) . . ." (Heb. 2.12-17)
- Heb. 12.22-24 - "*But you have come to Mount Zion and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem. . . "*
 - Jesus is our older brother and priest, leading us in worship! If worship is being united to Christ, the Crucified One, the main goal is God's glory in our midst, to become shaped into Christ himself.
 - Notice also the constant language of "in Christ" throughout Paul's letters.
 - Christ can't be our "worship leader" or be one with us without **some specific cultural form**. We want to see Christ glorified and embodied in every culture, so that the kingdom of God dwells everywhere. While on earth, the cultural form had to be a Jew in Palestine; now, it is to be any culture and place.
- "The worship and mission of the church are the **gift of participating** through the Holy Spirit in the incarnate Son's communion with the Father and the Son's mission from the Father to the world."
 - **"There is only one true Priest** through whom and with whom we draw near to God our Father. . . There is only one offering which is truly acceptable to God, and it is not ours. . . . That is why the Reformers, in their critique of certain medieval concepts of priesthood, stressed the sole priesthood of

Christ, and reinterpreted the church as a royal priesthood participating in the priesthood of Christ" (Torrance, 21).

- This worship "**enshrines the gospel of grace** . . . We are baptized into a life of communion." It unifies because there is only one way to come to the Father. And rather than weariness, it "releases joy and ecstasy. . . . In his love, [God] accepts us freely in the person of his beloved Son." (James Torrance, *Worship, Community and the Triune God of Grace*)